
ANNEX

Finding: Meta Incremental Attribution Is Not Measurement

A free tool that returns a confident number at any spend level.

Respect the Funk · marketing engine research program

Target: *Losing Sleep* — Hallow Youth · 15 July 2026

57 lines · 5 source links

Finding: Meta Incremental Attribution is not measurement

Status: Verified against Meta primary sources. Banked here during research; belongs in Pillar 03 (Audience Models) and cross-referenced from Pillar 02 (Meta Ads). **Date:** 2026-07-15

Primary sources

- [About Incremental Attribution](#)
- [How to Use Incremental Attribution in Meta Ads Manager](#)
- [How to View Results for Incremental Attribution](#)

What it actually is

Per Meta's own docs, Incremental Attribution is **an attribution-model setting driven by a predictive ML model — not a randomized experiment**. Meta describes it as using "machine learning models that predict whether a conversion is caused by an ad." That is the entire methodological disclosure. No holdouts, no control groups, no lift studies are mentioned on any of the three pages.

It reports a filtered subset of conversions you already had. Meta's own example: a campaign with 100 total conversions, 70 of which Meta considers incremental, shows 70 in the Results column.

Meta's careful wording on the results page is the tell: it is "designed to help you better understand the **relative** incrementality between Meta campaigns." That is a materially weaker claim than measuring true incremental lift. There is no control group for your account, therefore no account-specific counterfactual. **Meta is grading its own homework**. Treat it as an unfalsifiable vendor estimate, not as evidence.

Correction to industry folklore

The claim that it is "built on Meta's historical Lift study data / holdout testing" is widespread in agency content (Jonathan Snow, workmagic.io, threechaptermedia.com, bir.ch, easyinsights.ai) but **could not be traced to any Meta URL**. Treat as UNVERIFIED. [Social Media Today's coverage](#) is the most credible secondary source but is still trade press.

Vendor-circulated performance stats — Meta Q1 2025 earnings "average 46% lift", Q4 2025 "24% increase in incremental conversions" — come via secondary summaries and are **UNVERIFIED** against Meta investor relations. Do not cite without checking.

Why this is the most important small-budget finding so far

There is no published minimum spend, no minimum conversion volume, and no data-sufficiency threshold for results to display. This is a genuine absence, not a failed search — the eligibility constraints Meta does state are purely structural (objective, performance goal, bid control), exactly where a spend minimum would sit if one existed.

Contrast with [Conversion Lift](#), which states its \$5,000 / 500-conversion gate plainly, and which documents a "at least 100 conversions from test and control groups combined" threshold before results display.

The consequence: at \$500 of spend, Incremental Attribution will still show you a number. A real experiment refuses to report when it lacks power. This one never refuses. That is a silent-failure mode — the number looks identical whether it means something or nothing, and there is no in-product signal telling you which.

This is the canonical example for the "techniques that will not work at our scale" section. The danger isn't that the tool is unavailable; it's that it is available, free, and confidently wrong.

Usable constraints (verified)

CONSTRAINT	DETAIL
Campaign objectives	Sales, Engagement, or Leads
Conversion location	Website, or Website and app
Performance goals	Maximize number of conversions, or Maximize value of conversions
Bid controls	Cannot be used — Meta: "You cannot use bid controls when using incremental attribution"
Reversibility	None. "You cannot change your attribution model after you publish your campaign." Publish-time, irreversible — matters for a short campaign.
Data floor	Results unavailable for date ranges before April 1, 2025
Where	Ads Manager → Show more options → Attribution model → "Incremental"

Special ad category and pharmaceutical campaigns "may not have access to all Advantage+ features, or may see a different experience."

Recommendation

Switch it on — it's free, it works with the objectives we'd use anyway (Sales + Maximize conversions), and it's the only incrementality-flavored option available below Conversion Lift's \$5,000 gate.

But frame it in our own product and in anything we show a label as a **directional, Meta-graded estimate of relative incrementality — never as measurement**. If our engine surfaces this number to a client as "incremental streams," we would be laundering a vendor's self-assessment into an analytics product. That's a credibility risk for the engine that outweighs the metric's value.

Note the bid-control exclusion conflicts with cost-cap bidding strategies, and the irreversibility means it's a decision made once per campaign at publish time.